some perspective on

The New Pauline Perspective

Dan Lewis

THE NEW PAULINE PERSPECTIVE

Over the past four decades, a new way of understanding St. Paul has developed that has reshaped Pauline studies.

- *Not since the Protestant Reformation has there been such a reexamination of Pauline thought.*
- *Here, we shall attempt to "get a handle" on this new approach, its origins, basic ideas, and the pros and cons.*

MARTIN LUTHER AND ST. PAUL

To fully understand the dynamics of this new perspective, one needs to travel backward to the Protestant Reformation.

- *Luther broke with the Medieval Church in his understanding of Paul, and it is fair to say that his study of Paul led directly to his Reformation theology of salvation and the church.*
- *The new perspective on Paul, in turn, breaks with Luther's theology, and if followed, alters significantly one's understanding of both salvation and the church.*

LUTHER'S EPIPHANY (AD 1519)

"Certainly I had been possessed by an unusually ardent desire to understand Paul in his Epistle to the Romans. Nevertheless…I was hindered by the unique word in the first chapter: 'The righteousness of God…' I hated the word 'righteousness of God,' because in accordance with the usage and custom of the doctors I had been taught to understand it philosophically as meaning, as they put it, the formal or active righteousness according to which God is righteous and punishes sinners…"

"Day and night I tried to meditate upon the significance of these words… Then, finally, God had mercy on me, and I began to understand that the righteousness of God is that gift of God by which a righteous man lives, namely, faith, and that this sentence [indicates]…that the merciful God justifies us by faith. …Now I felt as though I had been reborn altogether and had entered Paradise. In the same moment the face of the whole of Scripture became apparent to me."

SINCE THE REFORMATION

Standard Protestant theology since the time of Luther has been that God imputes or confers the righteousness of Christ upon those who believe.

- *The believer, therefore, stands before God, not in his own righteousness, but clothed in the righteousness of Christ Jesus.*
- *The letters of Romans and Galatians, though written in the 1st century, have often been read against the background of the Medieval Church's works/righteousness theology.*

Enter the New Pauline Perspective

SECOND TEMPLE JUDAISM

The birth of the new Pauline perspective began, not with studies in Paul *per se*, but with a reevaluation of Judaism.

- *The default treatment of 2nd Temple Judaism had long been that it was an expression of severe legalism, much like the Medieval Church.*
- *The letters of Paul were read as combatting such legalism, both in his own era but equally applicable to the Medieval Church.*

THE PERCEIVED CONTRASTS

JUDAISM & THE MEDIEVAL CHURCH	PROTESTANT CHRISTIANITY
Salvation by works-righteousness	Salvation by grace alone
The hard yoke of religious law	Freedom in Christ
Fear of falling short	Full confidence in the victory of Christ
God seems remote	God is near
SALVATION IS EARNED!	**SALVATION IS A GIFT!**

REEXAMINING 1ST CENTURY JUDAISM

The New Pauline Perspective reexamines Judaism and arrives at a different understanding.

"New perspective" scholars are uncomfortable with:

- …anti-Semitic tendencies in Reformation theology
- …"replacement" theology (the belief that Jewish legalism was replaced by new covenant grace)
- …the belief that Judaism was religiously inferior

"New perspective" scholars argue that:

- …anti-Semitism is wholly unacceptable
- …"replacement" theology is misdirected, since Judaism held just as strong an emphasis on grace as did Pauline Christianity
- …any supposed inferiority of Judaism is a Christian caricature

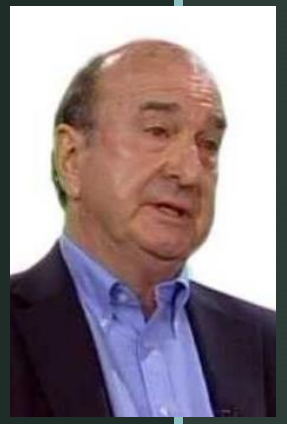
Examples of a more "gracious" Judaism from the Dead Sea Scrolls (4QS 11:12, 14)

"…as for me, if I stumble, <u>the mercies of God shall be my salvation always</u>; and if I fall in the sin of the flesh, in the justice of God, which endures eternally, shall my judgment be […]"

4QS 11:12

"…he will judge me in the justice of his truth, and in <u>his plentiful goodness always atone for all my sins</u>; in his justice he will cleanse me from the uncleanness of the human being and from the sin of the sons of man."

4QS 11:14



E. P. SANDERS

In 1977, E. P. Sanders (Duke University) published *Paul and Palestinian Judaism*, a new assessment of 2nd Temple Judaism that was much more generous.

- *Rather than strict legalism, he sought to demonstrate that the ancient texts of 1st century Judaism emphasized God's free election of Israel by divine grace.*
- *Salvation, for Jews, was a divine gift, not something they had to earn.*
- *Obedience to the commandments was expected, of course, but this was a <u>response</u> to divine grace, <u>not a means to achieve it</u>.*

So what?

DOES THIS MAKE A DIFFERENCE?

It is fair to say that Sanders convinced many if not most within the scholarly community that 1st century Judaism had been unfairly caricatured.

- *If Judaism, in fact, was a religion of grace, this in turn forces a reassessment of Paul.*
- *NT terms like "justification" and "the righteousness of God" and "the faith of Christ" must be understood differently than what was traditionally handed down by the Reformers.*

A question begged…

If Judaism was a religion of grace and faith, what then was Paul arguing against in his very emphatic language in Galatians and Romans about being justified by grace through faith and not by works?

JIMMY DUNN

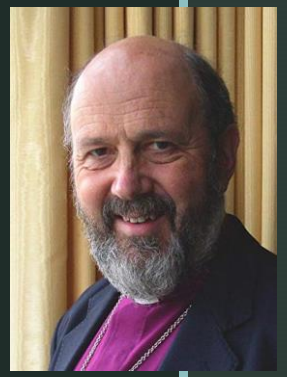
The advent of the New Pauline Perspective can be fixed with a 1982 lecture by James Dunn (University of Durham, England).

- *In interaction with E. P. Sanders, Dunn titled his lecture, “The New Perspective on Paul,” and suggested that Paul should no longer be read as the antithesis of legalistic Judaism.*
- *Paul was (and remained) a thoroughly Jewish theologian throughout his entire Christian career.*

DUNN AND THE WORKS OF THE LAW

Hence, Paul did NOT express a conflicting view with Judaism, but rather, a view that both he and Judaism held in common.

- *Dunn argued that Paul's phrase "the works of the law" referred not to a means of being saved, but rather, to those Torah observances that served as badges of Jewish identity.*
- *As such, Paul was not addressing the issue of salvation so much as the issue of how to identify God's people, or more specifically, how the Gentiles might be included within the boundaries of Israel.*



TOM WRIGHT

The Climax of the Covenant

- *In Wright's view, the problem of Israel with which Paul struggled was not salvation by works-righteousness (as Luther had mistakenly thought), but rather, a national exclusiveness that guaranteed Israel's salvation while leaving the non-Jewish nations on the outside.*
- *<u>Paul did not disagree with Judaism regarding grace, faith and righteous works; where he differed was regarding Jesus as the Messiah and the Lord.</u>*

The Gospel According to N. T. Wright

"When Paul refers to 'the gospel,' he is not referring to a system of salvation…nor even to the good news that there is a way of salvation open to all, but rather to the proclamation that the crucified Jesus of Nazareth has been raised from the dead and thereby demonstrated to be both Israel's messiah and the world's true Lord. 'The gospel' is not 'you can be saved, and here's how'; the gospel, for Paul, is 'Jesus Christ is Lord'."

10th Edinburgh Dogmatics Conference
"New Perspectives on Paul"
25-28 August 2003

"If Wright is right, then Luther was wrong!"

Alistair McGrath (Oxford University)

Wright and the New Perspective scholars seem to remove the keystone of Reformation theology (righteousness as a gift) and put in its place a theology of covenant inclusiveness.

In their view, faith in Christ (as opposed to works of the law) marks an individual as belonging to the covenant people rather than imputing to him/her the righteousness of Christ as a gift.

Comparing the Old and the New Perspectives

OF THINGS OLD AND NEW…

The Traditional Perspective: *In the Protestant Reformation, the "works of the law" were interpreted against the background of the Medieval Church and its doctrines of the treasury of merits, the sale of indulgences, and a "works-righteousness" theology. Hence, "works of the law" were understood to be any human acts of righteousness performed in order to gain credit with God.*

The New Perspective: *Here, the "works of the law" have a much narrower focus, referring specifically to those elements of Jewish law that accentuate Jewish privilege and mark out Israel from other nations. Hence, the "works of the law" are not a general reference to legalism per se but should be confined to things like Sabbath observance, circumcision, kosher food laws and the like.*

What is at stake in this discussion…the Reformation doctrine of justification by faith

- *New perspective scholars argue that many cherished concerns of the Protestant Reformation were either wrong or ill-conceived.*
- *While they do not propose to reevaluate Paul's teachings about the person of Christ, the Holy Spirit or the Christian life, <u>they do reassess what he says about works of the law and justification by faith [alone].</u>*

Two Perspectives

Reformation Perspective

- *Justification directly concerns how one is set right with God.*
- *It is a forensic metaphor for salvation itself—God's declaration of the sinner as righteous in light of faith in Christ's sacrifice on the cross.*
- *The "works of the law" are any attempt to be saved by legalism—salvation by keeping the law.*

New Perspective

- *Justification concerns those who have the right to call themselves God's people.*
- *It does **not** primarily concern the way to be saved; rather, it concerns the way one is identified.*
- *The "works of the law" are the attempt to define God's people by Sabbath observance, kosher laws, etc.*

Two Perspectives cont.--

Reformation Perspective

- *Justification primarily concerns the individual who stands guilty before God.*
- *Justification acquits the individual sinner, because God's wrath against sin fell upon the innocent substitute, Jesus Christ.*
- *The penalty for our sins fell upon Christ; his righteousness is imputed as a gift of grace.*

New Perspective

- *Justification primarily concerns the group—those who claim to be God's people.*
- *Justification is the announcement that the covenant boundary of God's people includes Gentiles, not merely Jews.*
- *The "righteousness of God" is his faithfulness to include Gentiles among his people.*

Two Perspectives cont.--

Reformation Perspective

- *<u>The gospel directly concerns the way of salvation.</u>*
- *The gospel is the "good news" that God offers a way to be saved outside the human capacity for perfect obedience.*
- *Salvation depends upon what Christ did, not upon what we can do.*

New Perspective

- *<u>The gospel does not concern a system of salvation; rather, it is the proclamation that Jesus is Lord.</u>*
- *Because Jesus is Lord, the call of the gospel is to accept him as Lord.*
- *The gospel is not so much about personal sin as about the victory of God.*

The Implications

Reformation Perspective

- *Paul's arguments in Galatians and Romans were driven by his concern for the standing of sinners before God.*
- *<u>The gospel is fundamentally about the salvation of sinners in view of Christ's sacrifice of atonement for all.</u>*

New Perspective

- *Paul's arguments were driven by his concern for social inclusivism and ecumenical unity.*
- *<u>The gospel is fundamentally about the triumph of Christ over sectarianism and Jewish exclusivism.</u>*

PAUL'S CONVERSION?

Some "new perspective" thinkers argue that on the Damascus Road, Paul was "called"—but he was not "converted."

- *What happened was not so radical as has been supposed.*
- *Paul did not change religions. Rather, he received a new and special calling as a Jew to bring God's message about Jesus to non-Jews.*
- *For Paul, justification has to do with relations between Jews and Gentiles, not with how a person is saved.*

Krister Stendahl

New Perspective Exegesis and Theology

Key Definitions: "the righteousness of God," "the works of the law," and "the faith of Christ"

FOUR BASIC CONCLUSIONS FRAMING THE NEW PAULINE PERSPECTIVE THEOLOGY

2nd TEMPLE JUDAISM WAS NOT A RELIGION OF WORKS-RIGHTEOUSNESS

- *Both Jesus and Paul were Torah observant Jews.*
- *Neither argued that Jews were no longer bound by Torah obligations.*

PAUL IS BEST UNDERSTOOD AS PART OF THE EMERGING RABBINIC MOVEMENT THAT WOULD COME TO DOMINATE JUDAISM AFTER THE 2nd TEMPLE'S DESTRUCTION.

- *Paul's arguments were not against Judaism per se, but against those who objected to his Gentile mission.*

PAUL'S AUDIENCE WAS GENTILES WHO NEVER FELL UNDER THE TORAH OBLIGATIONS OF THE JEWS

- *His churches included both Jews and Gentiles, and Paul understood his mission in terms of the great end-time ingathering of Gentiles as predicted by the OT prophets.*

PAUL WROTE BEFORE THE "PARTING OF THE WAYS" BETWEEN CHRISTIANITY AND JUDAISM

- *Christianity did not have an independent existence from Judaism during Paul's lifetime.*
- *His letters address the challenges of Jews and Gentiles co-existing in the same community, one body, one house, and one "loaf."*

δικαιοσύνη θεοῦ (= *righteousness of God*) Ro. 1:17; 3:5, 21, 22; 10:3; 2 Co. 5:21

If an Objective Genitive (here, the genitive refers to something God "gives") – This, of course, was Luther's "discovery" over against the Medieval notion of divine righteousness expressed in God's wrath.

- *Righteousness is what God confers upon the believer through faith.*
- *It contrasts with a righteousness based on legalism or Torah observance.*

If a Subjective Genitive (here, the genitive refers to a quality God "has") -- New Perspective scholars revert back to the pre-Reformation translation of righteousness, but they do NOT revert to the notion that it expresses divine wrath, but rather, God's covenant faithfulness.

- *The righteousness of God has to do with his faithful character.*
- *It contrasts with the unfaithfulness of Israel.*

- *As such, the "righteousness of God" in Romans is not about how a person receives the imputed righteousness of Christ by faith, but rather, how non-Jews, based on God's ancient promise to Abraham (Ge. 12:3), can now be considered part of God's people.*
- *Romans is less about individual salvation and more about corporate inclusion of Gentiles into the commonwealth of Israel: those who have faith in Jesus Christ are now included in the eschatological people of God.*

ἔργων νόμου (= “the works of the law”) Ro. 3:20, 28; Ga. 2:16; 3:2, 5, 10

Currently, the only extant 1st century Jewish document outside Paul that uses the expression “the works of the law” is a fragment from Qumran (4QMMT, 4Q394-399). In the Qumran Community, the “works of the Law” were a means of “reckoning righteousness.”

*“Now we have written to you some of <u>the works of the Law</u>… **And it will be reckoned to you as righteousness…”***

Altogether, some 20 precepts are listed, including:

- *Food laws*
- *Purity laws*
- *Intermarriage laws*
- *Bans on Gentile offerings*

- *If the "works of the law" have the more narrow focus of identity markers, then Paul was not arguing against legalistic self-righteousness in general, but rather, against those who emphasized exclusive Jewish election and excluded Gentiles from God's family.*
- *Paul's gospel, therefore, was that the Jews had wrongly restricted God's covenant promises to themselves.*
- *The badges of Jewish nationalistic exclusivism must give way to the new era of the messiah, when God was bringing people from all nations to believe in Jesus, just as the ancient prophets had predicted.*
- *The issue was not a new way of salvation (grace as opposed to works) but a new inclusiveness about who may belong to the people of God.*

πίστεως Χριστοῦ (= "the faith of Christ…") Ga. 2:16; Phil. 3:9

Critical Word Definition

πίστις as "faith"

πίστις as "faithfulness"

The important word πίστις can legitimately mean either "faith" or "faithfulness."

In key texts, Reformation theologians take it in the former sense and New Perspective theologians in the latter.

As an Objective Genitive (the traditional view)

Here, the phrase is translated as "faith in Christ" (so RV, ESV, NAB, NASB, NIB, NIV, NJB, NLT, RSV, NRSV)

As a Subjective Genitive (the new perspective)

Here, the phrase is translated as "the faithfulness of Christ" (so NET)

(The KJV is neutral and simply says "the faith of Christ.")

THE NEW PERSPECTIVE SHIFTS THE FOCUS OF FAITH FROM THE INDIVIDUAL BELIEVER TO THE COVENANT FAITHFULNESS OF CHRIST

In Reformation perspective, “the faith of Christ” means trust in God’s mercy alone rather than in any human act of righteousness, hence “faith in Christ.”

In the New Perspective, “the faith of Christ” is Jesus’ obedience to the Father’s will, fulfilling the ancient promise to Abraham of blessing to the nations, hence, “the faithfulness of Christ.”

THE NEW PAULINE PERSPECTIVE REORIENTS JUSTIFICATION BY FAITH

Justification by faith [alone] stands at the center of Reformation theology. For new perspective thinkers, it no longer stands at the center.

- *At the more extreme end, some "new perspective" thinkers reject Reformation theology altogether.*
- *Others claim not to reject the Reformation outright, but they do doubt the notion of imputed righteousness.*
- *Further, they tend to blur the distinction between Roman Catholic and Protestant theology vis-à-vis the synergism of faith plus good works.*

Paul's Metaphors for Salvation

ADOPTION

drawn from Roman family laws

…to transfer authority to a new family

JUSTIFICATION

drawn from the Roman criminal courts

…to be acquitted, to be pardoned by a judge

REDEMPTION

drawn from the Torah laws for buying back

to effect a release or to buy back

SUBSTITUTION

drawn from the sacrificial system of the temple

…to turn aside God's wrath against sin

SANCTIFICATION

drawn from the Torah laws for purification

…to make clean, fit to approach God

RECONCILIATION …repairing the breach between humans and God

Critique

Was Judaism a religion of grace, or did it have a theology of works-righteousness?

It seems questionable that the notion of salvation by "works of the law" can be eliminated from within Judaism so easily.

- *"The righteous…atones for (sins of) ignorance by fasting…" (Psalms of Solomon 3:7-8)*
- *"Our works (are) in the choosing and power of our souls… The one who does what is right saves up life for himself with the Lord…" (Psalms of Solomon 9:4-5)*
- *"But only prepare your heart so that you obey the Law… If you do this…you will not fall into the torment…" (2 Baruch 46:6)*
- *"…we know that we do not fall as long as we keep your statutes." (2 Baruch 48:22)*
- *"…as for…those who proved to be righteous on account of my Law…they may acquire and receive the undying world which is promised to them." (2 Baruch 51:3)*
- *"Miracles, however, will appear…to those who are saved because of their works and for whom the Law is now a hope…" (2 Baruch 51:7)*

The Gospel According to St. Paul

In any close reading of Paul, one cannot easily extract the idea of personal salvation and replace it with corporate inclusiveness.

- *"Now, brothers, I want to remind you of the gospel… By this gospel you are saved… 1 Co. 15:1-14).*
- *"For Christ [sent me]…to preach the gospel—not with words of human wisdom, lest the cross of Christ be emptied of its power. For the message of the cross is foolishness to those who are perishing, but to us who are being saved it is the power of God" (1 Co. 1:17-18).*
- *"Brothers, children of Abraham, and you God-fearing Gentiles, it is to us that this message of salvation has been sent. ..we tell you the good news… Therefore, my brothers, I want you to know that through Jesus the forgiveness of sins is proclaimed to you. Through him everyone who believes is justified from everything you could not be justified from by the law of Moses. …when the congregation was dismissed, many of the Jews and devout converts to Judaism followed Paul and Barnabas, who talked with them and urged them to continue in the grace of God." (Acts 13:26-43)*

"For by grace you have been saved through faith. And this is not your own doing, it is the gift of God, not a result of works, so that no one may boast" (Eph. 2:8-9).

"...for all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God, and are justified by his grace as a gift, through the redemption that is in Christ Jesus, whom God put forward as a propitiation by his blood..." (Ro. 3:23-25a)

Justification

The idea of sinners being set right with God cannot be easily extracted from the concept of justification.

- *Justification is not merely about Gentiles lying outside the Jewish circle; rather, it is fundamentally about humans—whether Jewish or Gentile—who lie outside God's saving favor and are equally guilty before him because of sin (Ro. 3:9).*
- *To relegate justification primarily to inclusion, ecumenism and tolerance is to extract out of it the personal dimension of sinners who need to be set right before God so that they might be "saved by him from the wrath of God" (Ro. 5:9).*
- *Being "saved" is equally an issue for Jews as well as Gentiles (Ro. 10:1).*

Imputed Righteousness

In several Pauline passages, the idea of righteousness as God's gift are not so easily dismissed.

- *"For if…death reigned…how much more will those who receive God's abundant provision of grace and of the gift of righteousness reign in life through the one man, Jesus Christ." (Ro. 5:17)*
- *"…that I may gain Christ and be found in him, not having a righteousness of my own that comes from the law, but that which is through faith in Christ—<u>the righteousness that comes from God</u> and is by faith." (Phil. 3:9; cf. Ro. 10:3)* **(Here, the preposition ἐκ θεοῦ clearly refers to God's gift of righteousness, not simply his righteous character.)**
- *"That is why his faith was 'counted to him [i.e., Abraham] as righteousness.' <u>But the words 'it was counted to him' were not written for his sake alone, but for ours also. It will be counted to us who believe in him who raised from the dead Jesus our Lord, who was delivered up for our trespasses and raised for our justification."</u> (Ro. 4:11-25)*

General Responses

RESPONSES TO THE NEW PAULINE PERSPECTIVE HAVE BEEN VIGOROUS AND VARIED

ACCEPTANCE

Here, the NPP is embraced as a better approach to Paul's letters, letting the theological chips fall where they may.

HERESY

Here, the NPP is viewed as a direct challenge to the gospel, indeed, "another" gospel, and is to be rejected outright.

VIA MEDIA

Here, the NPP calls for a reevaluation of Judaism without rejecting Reformation theology.

THE NEW PAULINE PERSPECTIVE SCHOLARS

It is important to point out that New Pauline Perspective adherents are not monolithic.

- *More extreme versions may reject Reformation theology outright and/or may imply, if not outright assert, that Jews should not be targeted for evangelism. They contend that the "Jewish Paul" never left Judaism or, for that matter, Pharisaism.*
- *More moderate thinkers, on the other hand, may deny the charge that they are anti-Lutheran, anti-Reformed and/or anti-Reformation, while still being willing to "adjust" some Reformation assumptions.*

THE HERESY CHARGE

The New Pauline Perspective and its perceived threat to central Reformation tenets are treated by some as an outright misdirection, especially by those from the Reformed and Lutheran conservative bodies.

- *It cannot be denied that some New Perspective scholars do indeed intend to overthrow the Reformation.*
  - **"The Reformation tradition's approach to Paul is [was] fundamentally wrong." (Francis Watson)**
- *Even for those who claim to remain within the Reformation tradition, significant changes are embraced with respect to understanding Paul, and these changes are incompatible with Christian orthodoxy.*

Some sample assessments…

"At stake is nothing less than the gospel itself… The new perspective ultimately offers a different gospel than that to which the Reformation bore witness."

Cornelius Venema (President, Mid-America Seminary)

"Rejection of the Reformation…is a big plank of the New Perspective."

Francis Watson (University of Aberdeen; University of Durham)

"The current revision of the doctrine of justification as formulated by the advocates of the so-called New Perspective on Paul is nothing less than a fundamental repudiation not just of that Protestantism which seeks to stand within the creedal and doctrinal trajectories of the Reformation but also of virtually the entire Western tradition on justification from at least as far back as Augustine."

Carl Trueman (Grove City College)

THE MIDDLE WAY

Some scholars are willing to acknowledge partial value in the New Pauline Perspective while at the same time urging caution.

- *The treatment of Judaism as a religion fully legalistic may have been an overstatement, but there remain clear strands of legalism in 1st century Judaism, a legalism against which Paul argued.*
- *Hence, while the basic exegesis of Paul in Reformation theology is valid, a more nuanced understanding of Paul as fully Jewish is in order.*

SHORT LIST OF SCHOLARS AND THEIR POSITIONS

New Perspective

- *James Dunn (University of Durham)*
- *Don Garlington (Toronto Baptist Seminary)*
- *Krister Stendahl (Harvard Divinity School)*
- *N. T. Wright (Oxford University; University of St. Andrews)*
- *Kent Yinger (George Fox Evangelical Seminary)*

Critical

- *D. A. Carson (Trinity Evangelical Divinity School)*
- *Donald Hagner (Fuller Theological Seminary)*
- *Cornelius Venema (Mid-America Seminary)*
- *Guy Waters (Reformed Theological Seminary)*
- *Stephen Westerholme (McMaster University)*

Both/And

- *Michael Bird (Crossway College)*
- *Douglas Campbell (Duke University)*
- *A. Andrew Das (Elmhurst College)*
- *Bruce Longenecker (Baylor University)*
- *Francis Watson (University of Aberdeen, University of Durham)*

For Consideration

1. *Do you think the New Pauline Perspective would require not only a reevaluation of Paul, but also, a reevaluation of Jesus (i.e., Jesus' debates with the Pharisees over legalism)?*

2. *If one adopts a theology of covenant inclusiveness (i.e., that Gentiles can now be included in the covenant of Israel), how might that affect our understanding of the new covenant (Jeremiah; Christ at the last supper)?*

3. *Luther contended that the Medieval Church was wrong, and it divided the church. New Perspective thinkers contend that Luther was wrong. What is the risk that this also might divide the church?*

4. *How much do you think the New Pauline Perspective, with its emphasis on inclusiveness, might be influenced by current cultural trends toward inclusiveness?*

5. *How might embracing the New Pauline Perspective affect missionary work?*

6. *The New Perspective thinkers seems to assume that Judaism was more or less monolithic—that it was <u>either</u> a religion of legalism (which they reject) <u>or</u> a religion of grace (which they accept). Could Judaism be sufficiently complex to have included both streams of thinking? (Even Christians have both streams of thinking!)*

7. *If one accepts the idea that Paul did not leave Judaism, even as a Christian, then was the eventual separation of Christianity from Judaism a colossal mistake?*

Personal Response

WHY THIS IS IMPORTANT

Theologies have come and gone over the centuries.

- *Some issues are more important than others, and their significance depends upon how directly they affect the core beliefs of Christianity.*
- *Inasmuch as the New Pauline Perspective affects such central issues as the gospel, the meaning of salvation, and the essential nature of the church, it must be considered primary.*
- *In wrestling with the various theological and exegetical issues raised by the New Pauline Perspective, I fall into the both/and category: some features that are emphasized in the New Perspective I can accept, ;other features I feel I must reject.*

WHERE THE NEW PERSPECTIVE GETS IT RIGHT

2nd TEMPLE JUDAISM AND EARLY CHRISTIANITY

That the earliest form of Christianity in Paul's lifetime was essentially a subset of Judaism must be frankly conceded.

- *This certainly was the perception of the Romans, which is evident in that Gallio threw out of court the Synagogue accusations against Paul, for as Gallio put it, the charge concerned "your own law," and he refused to adjudicate such things (Ac. 18:12-17).*
- *It is equally true that Christians themselves continued to consider the temple as sacred space (Ac. 2:46; 3:1; 5:12, 20-21, 42a; 21:20-26), attend synagogues (Ac. 6:9; Ja. 2:2), and function within the larger Jewish community (Ac. 11:19)*
- *After Paul's death (c. AD 64) and the destruction of Jerusalem and the temple (AD 70), and especially after the appearance of the birkat ha-minim, this perception would necessarily change, of course.*

THE JEWISHNESS OF PAUL

It seems clear that Paul retained a close connection with the larger body of Judaism, even after accepting Jesus as the Christ.

- *His continued participation in the synagogues, which includes Damascus (Ac. 9:20), Salamis (Ac. 13:5), Pisidian Antioch (Ac. 13:14), Iconium (Ac. 14:1), Thessalonica (Ac. 17:1), Berea (Ac. 17:10), Athens (Ac. 17:17), Corinth (Ac. 18:4), and Ephesus (Ac. 18:19; 19:8), suggest that he was willing to preach his message about Jesus from the standpoint of an insider within this traditional Jewish institution.*
- *His claim before the Sanhedrin to be a Pharisee (Ac. 23:6) is stated in the emphatic present tense (ἐγὼ Φαρισαῖός εἰμι =* "I am a Pharisee!").
- *His Nazirite vow (Ac. 18:18), which he intended to complete at the temple in Jerusalem (Ac. 21:23-26), marks him as Torah-observant.*

CHRIST AS MESSIAH AND LORD

It also seems clear that a constituent part of Paul's message was Jesus as Messiah and Lord, confirmed by Jesus' resurrection.

- *"…if you confess with your mouth that Jesus is Lord, and believe in your heart that God raised him from the dead, you will be saved" (Ro. 10:9).*
- *"For what we proclaim is not ourselves, but Jesus Christ as Lord…" (2 Co. 4:5; cf. Phil. 2:9-11; 1 Co. 8:6; 12:3).*
- *A very short summary comes in Paul's pithy description: "Remember Jesus Christ, raised from the dead, descended from David. This is my gospel…" (2 Ti. 2:8).*
- *It is to the point that Paul uses the word χρίστος (= Messiah, Christ) far more than any other writer in the NT.*

JESUS, THE FULFILLMENT OF THE STORY OF ISRAEL

A fundamental concept of fulfillment for Paul is that in Christ Jesus the story of Israel has come to its fulness.

- *Paul certainly sees that in Christ Jesus the ancient Torah has reached its climax, where Christ provides true freedom and the power to live righteously in a way the Torah was never able to provide (Ro. 8:2-4; Ga. 3:24).*
- *He agrees (with Jesus) that loving one's neighbor as oneself is the highest expression of the Torah (Ga. 5:14; Ro. 13:8-10; cf. Mk. 12:28-34; Lv. 19:18).*
- *The Jewish festival cycle, especially Passover and Unleavened Bread, reaches its climax in Jesus (1 Co. 5:7-8).*
- *Redemption from Egypt, including manna from heaven and water from the rock, have their highest meaning in foreshadowing Christ himself (1 Co. 10:1-4).*

THE TRUE AND FULL ISRAEL

While the default definition of Israel within Judaism was based on pedigree, Paul clearly indicates that the truest definition of God's people must be by faith in Jesus Christ.

- *Paul clearly affirms that ancient Israel was chosen by God as the recipients of adoption, glory, covenant, law, priesthood, promises, and the lineage of the Messiah (Ro. 3:1-2; 9:4-5).*
- *However, he also goes on to assert that the true "Israel" must be defined by faith (Ro. 2:28-29; 9:6-9; 10:8-13; 11:26; Ga. 3:6-9, 14, 26-29; 6:16).*
- *The corporate imagery he uses of the church—the body of Christ, the temple of God, the bride of Christ, the city community, and the household community—are metaphors describing the whole people of God, including both Jew and Gentile.*
- *This, then, is what he refers to as "all Israel" (Ro. 11:26) and the "Israel of God" (Ga. 6:16), which is to say, an Israel made up of both Jew and Gentile based on faith in Christ.*

THE CONTINUED RELEVANCE OF TORAH

While Paul clearly states that the Torah is inadequate to enable righteousness (Ro. 8:3), he still held a high regard for its moral relevance for Christians.

- *The Torah is the revelation of God's will: it is holy, righteous, good, and spiritual (Ro. 7:12-14, 16).*
- *A primary and necessary function of the Torah was to define and accentuate sin (Ro. 3:20; 5:13, 20a; 7:7, 13; Ga. 3:19; 1 Ti. 1:9-11).*
- *In various ways, Paul appeals to the Torah as a continuing moral guide (Ro. 2:13-16; 3:31; 7:22; 1 Co. 9:8-10; 14:34; 1 Ti. 1:8).*

ONE CHURCH, COMPOSED OF BOTH JEW AND GENTILE

That Paul perceived the church to be an undivided body of both Jew and Gentile seems a major emphasis.

- *It seems essentially correct that Paul understood his own mission to the Gentiles as the fulfillment of God's promise to the nations as predicted in the ancient prophets of Israel (Ro. 9:25-26; 10:11-17; 11:25-32; Ep. 3:4-6).*
- *Theologically, he argues that in Christ the "wall of hostility" between Jew and Gentile has been broken down so that both may have access to God as a single body, "one new man" (Ep. 2:11-22).*
- *Practically, he urges that Torah observant Jews and non-Torah observant Gentiles should be able to coexist without acrimony, so long as they live in love and mutual consideration (Ro. 14:1—15:7; 1 Co. 10:31-33).*

WHERE THE NEW PERSPECTIVE GOES TOO FAR

WHY I CANNOT FULLY EMBRACE THE NEW PAULINE PERSPECTIVE

While I think the New Perspective thinkers have emphasized some important ideas in Paul that have sometimes been neglected or missed, it seems to me that they push too far.

- *Some of their theological claims seem out of balance.*
- *Some of their exegetical claims seem to ignore clear meanings in the Greek text and end up largely being based on ambiguities and the logical fallacy, "If you can't prove I'm wrong, I must be right."*
- *In general, I agree with the critique offered earlier that one cannot extract out of Paul's letters the basic idea that in the gospel he was talking about individual salvation.*

THE RIGHTEOUSNESS OF GOD

The conclusion that the "righteousness of God" must be taken as a subjective genitive is at best unclear. The concept of righteousness seems to be applied <u>both</u> to God's character <u>and</u> as a gift to those who believe.

- *True, the sacrifice of Christ was made precisely to show God's righteous character (Ro. 3:25-26), a covenant faithfulness that stands in opposition to Israel's unfaithfulness (Ro. 3:3-6).*
- *At the same time, righteousness as something that God gives to sinners because of their faith seems clearly stated (Ro. 4:3-8, 11, 13, 20-25; 5:17; 9:30; 10:4; 1 Co. 1:30; 2 Co. 5:21; Ep. 4:24; Phil. 3:9). The phrase* δωρεᾶς τῆς δικαιοσύνης *(= gift of righteousness) in Ro. 5:17 <u>is</u> clear and unambiguous.*
- *The ambiguous genitive "righteousness of God" (Ro. 1:17; 3:5; 10:3) can theoretically go in either direction, but in the larger context of Paul's discussion, I think the case is strong that Luther was correct in taking it as an objective genitive.*

A GRAMMATICAL ADDENDUM

Something not obvious to the English reader but quite obvious to the Greek reader is that the phrase "righteousness of God" in Ro. 1:17 and 3:21-22 is anarthrous, which is to say, it has no definite article.

- *Hence, the Greek text reads "[a] righteousness of God," not "[the] righteousness of God," though most English Versions add the definite article "the" for English smoothness.*
- *To be sure, anarthrous constructions in Greek are not always indefinite, but often they are used to refer to a member of a class.*
- *In the case of "[a] righteousness of God," it seems to me that this righteousness very well may indicate a member of a class, especially when in the larger argument of Romans it is contrasted with "righteousness by law" or "righteousness that is self-established" or "righteousness by obedience", etc.*
- *The anarthrous character of this phrase, it seems to me, better suits an objective genitive than a subjective genitive.*

IMPUTATION

The effort to dismiss the idea of imputation seems to directly conflict with the basic definition of λογίζομαι (= to credit, impute, reckon, to be considered), particularly when it is used directly concerning righteousness.

- *If God "counted" Abraham righteous because he believed, and if this reckoning is to be understood as "a grace-gift" (χάρις) as opposed to something earned, it is hard to see how such a gift can be understood in any way other than as imputation (Ro. 4:3-5, 9).*
- *The same is true of the phrase concerning David (Ro. 4:6): θεὸς λογίζεται δικαιοσύνην χωρὶς ἔργων (= God reckons righteousness without works).*
- *In the same way, then, God imputes righteousness to those who believe (Ro. 4:11, 22-24).*

JUSTIFICATION

Redefining justification so that it refers to legitimizing Gentiles within the Jewish covenant rather than acquittal of sin seems unwarranted.

- *The verb δικαιόω (= to justify) is directly linked with sin and moral accountability (Ro. 2:12-13; 3:19-20, 23-24; 6:7; 8:33-34; 1 Co. 6:9-11; Ga. 2:17; 3:22-24).*
- *Believers are justified by Christ's blood precisely so they can be saved from divine wrath (Ro. 5:9).*
- *In the discussion of Abraham, who is justified by faith rather than by works (Ro. 4:2), it is very hard to see how his justification qualifies as an identity badge in a context where there is no covenant community to which to belong.*
- *It is to the point that the character of Abraham's justification derives from the God "who justifies the ungodly" (Ro. 4:5), and this seems oriented toward sinfulness, not identity.*

THE FAITH OF CHRIST

The ambiguity of the genitives in Ga. 2:16 and Phil. 3:9 (διὰ πίστεως χριστοῦ = *"through faith of Christ")* does not warrant the overthrow of the major English translations.

- *Almost all the English Versions render this as an objective genitive, i.e., "through faith [in] Christ" (so RV, RSV, NRSV, NAB, NASB, NIV, NIB, NJB, ESV). The major exception is the NET ("the faithfulness of Christ" or "Christ's faithfulness"). The KJV is neutral (i.e., "faith of Christ").*
- *To be sure, one cannot simply tally up translations as though this were a popular vote, but nonetheless, the burden of proof is on the exception rather than the norm.*

SUBSTITUTIONARY ATONEMENT

While there has been ongoing debate about the Christus Victor and Penal Satisfaction theories of atonement (*a la* Anslem, Aulen, etc.), there are strong exegetical grounds for the concept of substitution, <u>and the two emphases need not be mutually exclusive</u>.

- *Paul certainly conceives of salvation within the larger context of Israel's sacrificial system (1 Co. 5:7; Ep. 5:2; Ro. 3:25; 1 Co. 11:23-25).*
- *Frequently, he uses the word "blood" as a synecdoche for Jesus' death, which also suggests sacrifice (Ro. 3:25; 5:9; 1 Co. 10:16; 11:25, 27; Ep. 1:7; 2:13; Col. 1:20).*
- *He also uses the critical prepositions* περί (= for, concerning), *i.e., Christ died "for sin" (Ro. 8:3; 1 Th. 5:10), and* ὑπέρ (= in behalf of*), i.e., Christ died "for the ungodly" (Ro. 5:6) and he died "for us" (Ro. 5:8; cf. Ro. 8:32; 1 Co. 1:13; 5:7; 11:24; 15:3; 2 Co. 5:14-15, 21; Ga. 1:4; 2:20; 3:13; Ep. 5:2, 25; 1 Ti. 2:6; Tit. 2:14).*
- *It is difficult to conceive of these prepositions other than in the larger concept of a life debt that is satisfied in the death of Jesus.*

THE WORKS OF THE LAW

The conclusion that the "works of the law" (Ro. 3:20, 28; Ga. 2:16; 3:2, 5, 10) refer not to a way of salvation, but rather, to identity markers is theoretically possible but questionable.

- *The larger context of Paul's letters seem oriented toward salvation, and if by "works of the law" he speaks only of identity markers, it would be the exception.*
- *There is good reason to read MMT (the Qumran document citing "works of the law") as referring to legalistic salvation (not merely identity marks), and the striking contrast between MMT's "the works of the law…will be reckoned to you as righteousness" and Paul's assertion that "faith…is reckoned to you as righteousness" could hardly be sharper.*

THE INDIVIDUAL vs. THE GROUP

In reducing the emphasis on the individual, the New Perspective can leave ambiguous just how a person is saved.

- *It seems to open the door to universalism—that because of Christ's resurrection and exaltation, all Gentiles are now "in," whereas before they were "out." This, of course, would cut the nerve of any missionary effort.*
- *Paul uses the emphatic 1st person "I" to refer to his own experience of grace and faith (Ga. 2:18-21). When he says, "…the life I now live in the flesh I live by faith in the Son of God who loved me and gave himself for me" and "I do not nullify the grace of God…" it is hard to believe that he is speaking only generally and not about himself as an individual.*

JEWISH SALVATION

If the Jews were already "in" by divine gracious choice, why does Paul even seek to convince them of Jesus' messiahship and link it to the idea of being saved?

- *As he himself puts it, the gospel is first to the Jew (Ro. 1:16), and in his preaching, he includes the "children of Abraham" to whom the message of salvation has been sent (Ac. 13:26).*
- *In Luke's record of Paul's missionary work, he consistently describes his initial stop in virtually any city he visited as the synagogue, where he preached Christ. This included the message that "through this man [Jesus] forgiveness of sins is proclaimed" (Ac. 13:38). The response to Jewish rejection was, "Your blood be on your own heads" (Ac. 18:6).*
- *Paul's deep anguish for his "kinsmen according to the flesh" (Ro. 9:2-3) is rather pointedly <u>that "they might be saved"</u> (Ro. 10:1).*

At the end of the day…

While I can appreciate a number of the features of the New Pauline Perspective and continue to respect many of the scholars who embrace it, I conclude that at critical points I must decline their reading of St. Paul.